Gelling and the Yonggyap Valley. Further to the west, inhabiting the Mechuka Valley, is the other Buddhist tribe, the Memba, who are originally said to have migrated east from Tawang centuries ago. Like the Monpa, they too are deeply religious and virtually every aspect of their life is moulded by their religion. Even though the Memba are followers of Buddhism, they continue to worship some of their pre-Buddhist animistic deities. As a result, their faith is a mix of two different cultures.

The tribes in the region (mainly Abor, now known as Adi) were not only hostile to the British, they were extremely violent to any ingress into their area even from the north. Every British thrust into the region prior to 1910 was met with fierce resistance. Interestingly, beyond the watershed, the people north of the McMahon line, by and large, rarely ventured into these tribal belts, though the tribes themselves would regularly come north to trade, following a barter system. This was also true of the entire Subansiri River watershed, known as the Bokar region, which lay further east of Mechuka and extended up to the Kameng frontier.

South of the McMahon Line the Siang (also referred to as the Dihang River) flows in a north-south direction and forms the nucleus for the dendritic drainage system of the Himalayas. The ‘riddle of the Tsangpo Gorge’ was one of the world’s biggest geographical mysteries until the early twentieth century when Captains Morshead and Bailey confirmed that the Siang was indeed the Tsangpo. After it enters NEFA just north of Gelling, the various subsidiary streams on the NEFA side, all part of the dendritic drainage system, add their substantial volume of water to the mighty Siang. After it debouches into the plains at Pasighat, the river joins the Lohit River that has already merged with the Dibang near Sadiya to form the Brahmaputra.

The southern side of the Loyul area is the main territory of the Adi Minyong tribe. They inhabit both banks of the Siang from the Tuting area to the plains of Assam. The Adi Minyong initially stubbornly resisted British attempts to subjugate this region. But in 1862 the Minyong were forced to negotiate. They accepted British sovereignty up to the foothills but their relations remained strained until 1912.

Towards the extreme east, bordering Burma, the Chinese claim that the Lower Tsayul area (Lohit River Valley) originally belonged to Tibet. In the mandate given by the Dalai Lama in 1896, it was stated that the region of both the Upper and Lower Tsayul, the area would be under the